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本科生毕业论文

题目：自由意志怀疑论的一种语义学回应

A Semantic Response to Free Will Scepticism

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摘要

本文讨论了自由意志怀疑论，它与外部世界怀疑论的相似性，以及摩尔和维特根斯坦共同致力的对外部世界怀疑论的解决方案。本文提出了一个与之平行的对自由意志怀疑论的语义学回应，并辩护了极小自由意志论题（MFT），即某些人在某些时候行使自由意志。本文论证，任何对 MFT 的怀疑都可以被证明是错的，而任何看起来是对 MFT 的怀疑但不能被证明是错的怀疑，都是无意义的。

关键词：自由意志，怀疑论，无意义，决定论

ABSTRACT

This essay discusses scepticism of free will, its similarity with scepticism of an external world, and a solution to scepticism of an external world that Moore and Wittgenstein worked towards. The essay presents a parallel semantic response to scepticism of free will and defends the minimal free will thesis (MFT), which holds that someone sometimes wills freely. It is argued that any doubt about MFT can be proved to be false, but whatever appears to be doubt about MFT that cannot be proved to be false is nonsense.

KEY WORDS: free will, scepticism, nonsense, determinism

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第一章 引言[①]

我们有自由意志吗？关于这个扣人心弦的问题的争论古老但持久。特别是近几十年来的科学发展使这个问题再次成为讨论中心（韩水法，2019）。自由意志怀疑论者认为，自由意志并不存在，因为自由意志与决定论不相容，而决定论很可能是对的。然而，大多数人觉得自由意志对于我们自己和他人的概念如此重要，以至于几乎不可能抛弃它。

外部世界怀疑论和自由意志怀疑论在论证结构和问题的重要性方面存在诸多相似之处。在本文中，摩尔和维特根斯坦用于处理前一个问题的反怀疑论策略被应用于后者。本文辩护了极小自由意志论题（MFT），即某个人在某些时候行使自由意志。文章进一步暗示极小自由意志论题及其普遍化能够提供值得欲求的那种自由意志。

本文分为三个主要部分。第一部分考虑了“自由意志”一词的两种解释、来自决定论的威胁以及自由意志的重要性。第二部分讨论了维特根斯坦式无意义，及其如何被应用于外部世界怀疑论的解决方案。第三部分发展了对极小自由意志论题（MFT）的论证，其使用了一个思虑（deliberation）的案例和无意义（nonsense）的哲学批评。

[①] 本文最初使用英文写作，而后翻译成中文，原文全文请见附录。

第二章 自由意志之为问题

2.1 自由意志的解释

传统上，自由意志被认为是一种控制自己选择和行动的能力。然而，如何确定自由意志的确切本质或详细内容是困难的。当代哲学家对这一术语形成了两种主要解释。

第一种是“岔路派理论”， 以主体面临的多重可能性来解释自由意志（见 van Inwagen, 1983）。当主体对某一选择或行动行使自由意志时，她对于该选择或行动有多重可能性（alternative possibilities），也就是说，她可以以一种方式进行选择或行动，也可以做出其他的选择或行动。历史文献显示这是自由意志的一个被广泛承认的特征。例如，亚里士多德说 “当我们在自己能力范围内行动时，不行动也在我们的能力范围之内，反之亦然[②]”（2009:1113b6）。康德认为，对于真正的自由来说，“行为以及它的反面在其发生的那一刻都必须是主体的能力范围之内”（1960:45）。

第二种是“源头派理论”，强调自由的选择或行动“属于”主体（Kane, 1998; Pereboom, 2014）。根据这一解释，主体对某一选择或行动行使自由意志当且仅当她（而非其他人或是她控制之外的因素）是该选择或行动的源头。这一对源头或起源的强调同样能在历史文献中看到：亚里士多德将违反意愿的被迫行为刻画为“其始因是外在的”，例如当一个人“被飓风裹挟”（2009:1110a2）时。一些哲学家认为自由意志需要主体在一种终极意义上是她选择和行为的源头。例如，罗伯特·凯恩（Robert Kane）使用自由意志一词来指代“主体成为他们自己的目的或目标的终极创造者（或起源者）、维持者的能力”。

这两种解释之间的关系存在着争议。例如，哈里·法兰克福（Harry Frankfurt, 1969）和丹尼尔·丹内特（Daniel Dennett, 1984）认为，自由意志不需要岔路派理论的做出其他选择的能力。拿丹内特的例子（1984:133）来说，当路德说出“我在这里。我无法不这么做。”（I am here. I cannot do otherwise.）并与罗马教会决裂时，路德的道德品格使他无法做出其他行动，但路德这么说并不是在逃避而恰恰相反是在承担他行为的全部责任。如果我们将自由意志与道德责任联系起来，就不能假设自由意志要求主体 “本可以不这么做”(could have done otherwise)。作为对比，凯恩认为，要成为自己的行为的终极源头或者为自己的行为承担终极责任，在一个人的一生中至少需要存在一些具有多重可能性的行为（1984:72）。我认为这两种解释都直观地捕捉到了自由意志意义的某些属性，本文不会偏向于某一种理论。

2.2 决定论的挑战

传统的自由意志概念受到了决定论的威胁，有如下两点原因。

首先，对自由意志的无论何种解释与一般的决定论论题（the general thesis of

[②] 文章中所有引文均参考已有的中文译本（也列入文末参考文献）译自英文参考文献。

determinism）之间都存在着张力。作为例子，我们将考虑因果决定论论题：每一个事件都是由先前发生的事件和条件以及自然法则所决定的。考虑自由意志的“岔路派理论”：如果因果决定论是对的，那么在某个时间 t，事情的发展方式（包括主体的选择或行动）是固定的，因为 t 之前的事件和自然法则都是固定的。由此可见，当一个主体选择以一种方式行动时，她没有选择以另一种方式行动的实际可能性；因此，她没有自由意志。考虑自由意志的 “源头派理论”：如果因果决定论是对的，那么主体的选择和行动是由过去的事件和自然法则决定的。由此可见，基因、过去的事件连同物理和生物规律，而非她自己，才是她选择的真正来源；因此，她没有自由意志。看起来，无论根据何种解释，自由意志的存在都与因果决定论不相容。

第二，有强烈的动机认为一般的决定论论题是对的。在历史上，这种动机是神学的（例如，波爱修讨论了神的预知和人类自由的问题）或形而上学的，而自近代以来，这一动机越来越是科学的。牛顿物理学的成功促成了近代时期的决定论世界观，有人认为二十世纪初的量子革命能够挑战这种决定论世界观。然而，目前存在对量子力学的决定论和非决定论的解释，许多思想家也对量子力学与意识和自由意志的相关性持有怀疑（见 Hodgson, 2011）。例如，丹内特（1984:77）认为，世界（包括我们的大脑）中的微观量子效应不涉及人类行动的宏观不确定性。

神经科学的进步也促使了对决定论的信念，因为神经科学家通过将人类行为与大脑中的局部活动联系起来，对人类行为提供越来越准确的解释和预测。值得注意的是，神经科学家本杰明·李贝特（Benjamin Libet, 1985）进行了一些实验，其似乎揭示了特定的神经活动模式可靠地出现在人们有意识的行动决定之前，而韦格纳（Wegner, 2002）基于这些发现论证自由的意愿体验是“一种幻觉”。

2.3 自由意志的重要性

尽管决定论对自由意志提出了严重挑战，但自由意志的概念在人类生活的许多方面具有根本的重要性，以至于几乎不可能抛弃它。如果没有自由意志，我们作为深思熟虑和理性的主体的概念将被大大削弱，甚至完全丧失。这至少有两个主要后果。

其一是道德责任将没有空间。要使一个主体负有道德责任，她的选择和行动需要是自愿的，即出于她自己的自由意志。如果一个主体的行为纯粹是由她无法控制的因素决定的，又或者她别无选择，那么指责她似乎是不公平的。因此，如果自由意志不存在，我们似乎就不能像我们通常所做的那样将道德责任归于行为主体。其结果是深远的：从人际关系到司法实践，甚至到道德的基本概念，人类生活的所有道德方面都将受到不利的影响。

另一个是自我决定（self-determination）和自我统治（self-governance）的概念将受到危害。如果我们生活中的选择和行动不是（最终）来自于我们自己，而是来自于例如我们的基因和养育环境，那么我们似乎并非我们自己人生的设计师，而是（完全）受制于外部因素的操纵。与这种自我决定的概念密切相关的是自我统治的概念。例如，康德将自由意志

与“自主”（autonomy）或“自我立法”（self-legislation）联系起来，即能够按照自己选择的法则行事，而不是仅仅按照自然法则或其他人强加的规则行事（1998：52）。康德认为，如果没有一种原初的、起源性的自由意志，人的行动将完全受制于并非他们自己创造的法则。

本文的主要关注点是与第二种重要性有关的自由意志。本文不会——至少不会明确地——讨论道德责任、值得责备和值得赞扬等概念。

第三章 应对外部世界怀疑论的策略

3.1 怀疑论论证和相似性

自由意志的问题可以被处理为一种怀疑论问题——问题的核心是对某种在人类生活中极具价值且我们通常认为理所当然的东西（例如自由意志的存在）的怀疑。事实上，对自由意志的怀疑论与对外部世界（知识）的怀疑论有着类似的结构和特征。两种论证都是从普通的、局部的怀疑到不寻常的、全局的怀疑，运用常识的一个部分来挑战常识的其他部分。

知识论中的怀疑论论证开始于一个寻常的观察，即我们有时不具有我们误以为自己拥有的知识，例如视错觉的例子。这一推理随后被应用于不寻常的怀疑论场景，如笛卡尔的恶魔：由于我们可能处于这种场景中，我们并不具有我们通常认为自己拥有的对外部世界的知识。

同样，对自由意志的怀疑论也是从有时我们的意志并不自由这一常识开始的，例如吸毒成瘾的情形。这一局部的操纵被普遍化为全局的操纵：是否我们所有的选择或行动都被其他力量控制或决定——无论这个力量是基因、自然法则或是命运？我们会不会在任何情况下都缺乏自由意志？

问题的相似性促使我们研究类似的反怀疑策略是否能发挥作用。摩尔在一系列论文中对外部世界的怀疑论做出了回应，包括《维护常识》（A Defense of Common Sense）和《对外部世界的证明》（Proof of an External World）。维特根斯坦在《论确定性》（On Certainty）（该手稿由他对摩尔前述两篇论文的思考所激发）中也处理了外部世界怀疑论的问题。存在着不同的对这两位哲学家的反怀疑策略的解读。最近，王小塞（Sebastian Sunday Grève, 2022）指出他们的策略之间存在“完美的契合”，并认为摩尔和维特根斯坦正在努力实现相同的解决方案，只是没能完成他们的工作。这个解决方案在本质上是逻辑的或语义的：“任何对外部世界存在的怀疑都可以被证明是错的，而任何看起来是对外部世界存在的怀疑但不能被证明为错的[怀疑]，都是无意义的，因为它必须依赖于对逻辑上不可能的东西的断言”。

3.2 维特根斯坦式无意义

这一“无意义”（nonsense）的批评与维特根斯坦的意义观有着深刻的联系。当维特根斯坦在《哲学研究》第 43 节中说“对于‘意义’这个词的利用的诸情形中的一个大类来说——即使并非对于其利用的所有情形来说——人们可以以这样的方式解释这个词：一个语词的意义就是其在语言中的使用”时，他经常被理解为提出了一种“意义的用法理论”（use-theory of meaning）。然而，正如詹姆斯·科南特（James Conant, 1998）所评论的，这种对用法的强调不应该被解释为只是在我们的语法理论和语义理论之上加上第三层自然语言

的语用。“一个表达式的意义”并不像“伴随着这个词的一个雾气圈”一样为表达式所固有地拥有，然后被带到每个使用场合中。只有在其表达意义的语境中、在语句实际被使用的特殊情境中，语句才确实有意义。

根据这种解释，维特根斯坦“无意义”的批评并不是说在某些语境中某些表达式的组合本身是无意义的。他对怀疑论者的“无意义”指控的关键点在于，不清楚怀疑的表达式的使用语境（context of use）应该是什么；正是这种对使用语境的混淆导致了该表达式不能表达确定的意思——因而不能产生意义。维特根斯坦有时将这种无意义的言说描述为“在语言游戏之外言说”或“语言度假去了”，也就是说，这些语词在实际使用情境（actual circumstances of use）中没有工作——未能发挥作用。我们确实应该问问怀疑论者：他们在用他们的语词做什么？

科南特回答道，怀疑论者困惑于他们的语词：他们想用他们的语词表达不止一个意思。他总结道，怀疑论者面临着两难境地：要么“他留在我们的语言游戏中，他的语词表达了一种怀疑，但不是他所追求的那种超级怀疑（不是那种会威胁到知识的可能性的怀疑）”，要么“他将‘在语言游戏之外’言说，而他假定的具体使用情景被剥去了”。维特根斯坦将后一种情况称为“意义的幻觉”——我们误以为自己知道我们的语词是什么意思，但事实上并不知道我们用这些语词在表达什么。

3.3 怀疑论的一种解决方案

作为一个例子，我们在这里考虑一个怀疑论者，他对“这里有一只手”表示怀疑。那么，他可能想表达：这不是一只人的手，而是一个假肢，或者这不是一只真正的手，而是由某个投影仪产生的图像。这些都是经验性的命题，在正常情况下可以被证明是错误的。对此，怀疑论者又在他的怀疑中加入了怀疑论场景：“你可能在做梦！你怎么知道这里有一只手？”那么我们应该问为什么做梦会损害我们的知识。我们通常使用的“做梦”的概念指的是一种暂时的体验，在这种体验中我们的认知能力和感官体验都比不上清醒状态下的能力和体验。正是在这样一种体验中，我们不具备关于外部世界的知识——在梦中出现的一些物体可能实际上并不存在。然而，可以说，我们现在所经历的生动的感官体验和记忆（连同连贯的思维过程）并不像我们通常使用“梦”这个词意义下的梦。因此，怀疑论者在其新的怀疑表达中实际所指的梦的概念应该与我们现在的梦的概念有根本的区别。这就是王小塞在他的论文结尾处的考虑，这一考虑承接摩尔在《确定性》（Certainty）一文中的发问“这在逻辑上是否可能：我既拥有这一切的感官体验和记忆，却又同时在做梦”。

此外，根据维特根斯坦，“我不知道这里有一只手（等等）”这样的一系列错的信念不等同于一系列错误（mistake），而等同于心智错乱（mental disturbance）。在《论确定性》第 67 节和第 71 节中，维特根斯坦考虑了这样一种情况：有人不断地在我们通常不会犯错的地方犯错，比如“他说他住在这样那样的地方，有这样那样的年龄，来自这样那样的城市，他说话时有着和我一样的确定性（给出所有的标志），但他是错的”。维特根斯坦得出结论：

像这样的一次性的错的信念也许能被称为错误，但经常性的一系列相当数量的这种错的信念是“一种心智错乱，也许是一种短暂的错乱”。因为这种错误在逻辑上是不可能的——类似于“这里有一个物体”这样的命题（或者某人住在这样那样的地方，是这样那样的年龄的命题）拥有着独特的逻辑地位。这种不可能性在下列评论中得到了重申：

155. 在某些情境中一个人不可能犯错……

220. 一个有理智的人不会有某些怀疑。

第四章 对自由意志怀疑论的回应

4.1 一个选择的案例

在这一节中，我将论证自由意志至少在极小的意义上存在。为论证起见，我将辩护下面定义的极小自由意志论题（Minimal Free will Thesis， MFT）。这是一个弱的论题，其显然是“我们有自由意志”的必要条件。它也许是也许不是“我们有自由意志”的充分条件，但我认为如果下面对 MFT 的辩护成功的话，对 NFT（Normal Free will Thesis）这样更强的论题的辩护不存在太多困难。

(MFT) **极小自由意志论题**[③] 某个人在某些时候行使自由意志。

具体来说，这意味着在某些时候，某人对于她的选择或行动有（岔路派理论）多重可能性，并且（源头派理论）她是该选择或行动的来源。

(NFT) **正常自由意志论题** 在正常的情况下，正常人以一种合理的频率行使自由意志。

我的策略最好通过一个例子来展示，这个例子设置在一个普通的情景中，没有什么不寻常的地方。

（安娜与简） 安娜和简最近都申请了研究生院；安娜得到了三所学校的录取通知，但简只得到了一份录取通知。安娜有强大的动机想要选择每一个选项，原因各不相同且不可通约（immensurable）[④]。经过一段时间的思虑（deliberating），她终于扫除了内心的不确定和不坚定，做出了选择。简对提供给她的唯一选项感到失望，但她还是不情不愿地接受了这个录取通知。

对 MFT 的证明可以这样表述：

(1) 如果 MFT 是错的，那么安娜和简在选择学校时都不行使自由意志。
(2) 如果安娜和简在选择学校时不行使自由意志，那么安娜和简在选择学校时都没有多重可能性（alternative possibilities）。
(3) 如果 MFT 是错的，那么安娜和简在选择学校时都没有多重可能性。
(4) 并非如此：安娜和简在选择学校时都没有多重可能性。
(5) 因此，MFT 是对的。

③ 这改编自彼得·范·英瓦根（Peter van Inwagen, 1983:91）使用的术语。
④ “不可通约的不同可能性”这一条件来自凯恩（1998:167）。这个案例的整体设计受凯恩的“形成自我的行动”（self-forming action）理论影响。

前提（1）是 MFT 定义的否定应用于安娜和简选择学校的特殊情境。前提（2）来自于自由意志的“岔路派”解释。（3）由（1）和（2）推出。（5）由（3）和（4）根据 *modus tollens* 规则推出。这个论证在形式上是有效的，且前提（1）（2）（3）都为真。为了建立论证的可靠性，我们只需要证明前提（4）。

为了证明前提（4），考虑在安娜和简选择研究生院的这一实际使用情境中“安娜和简在选择学校时都没有多重可能性”这一表达式。当安娜仔细权衡每所学校的利弊、想象如果她选择了某个选项未来会是什么样子、并在几个选项之间反复来回时，她是在多种可能性中进行选择。即使安娜最终解决了心中的不确定并选择了学校 A，她本也很可能选择学校 B 或 C，因为她对每个选项都有同样强大而互不相同的动机[⑤]。然而，简不需要、而且事实上也不能在学校之间进行选择（假设简非常想继续读研究生且此时不考虑其他的人生可能性）。我们和简自己都知道，她早在最后的决定时间之前就要去这个特定的学校。她在选择学校时并没有多重可能性。

与外部世界怀疑论一样，“无意义”的哲学批评也适用于此。“安娜和简在选择学校时都没有多重可能性”这一表达式在这个使用语境下将做什么并不清晰。这一表达式的运用是否使得安娜没有必要思虑？当然不。自由意志怀疑论者可能想针对一种真正的或深刻的“多重可能性”，但他混淆了使用语境。这种混淆导致该表达在任何实际的使用情境中都无法发挥作用，因此不再具有意义。同样，自由意志怀疑论者也面临着两难境地：要么他的话语表达了对多重可能性的怀疑，但不是他怀疑 MFT 时所针对的那种多重可能性；要么他的话语未能起作用因而没有意义。因此，要么“安娜和简在选择学校时都没有多重可能性”是假的（因此（4）是真的），要么“安娜和简在选择学校时都没有多重可能性”的表达式是无意义的[⑥]。

为了以一种更直观的方式展现“安娜和简在选择学校时都没有多重可能性”这一表达式的无意义，考虑如下场景。不知怎得安娜相信她在选择学校时没有多重可能性，因此她像简一样没有必要思虑。她确信思虑是不必要的，于是决定使用掷骰子的方式来决定去哪所学校。如果安娜真的通过掷骰子来决定学校选择（而非收集信息、仔细思考），那么我们不会说安娜缺乏多重可能性或者安娜意志不自由，相反我们会说她漠不关心、对自己不负责。想象一下安娜使用这种方式来决定她人生中的所有重大选择，那么我们会说她自暴自弃。这个有趣的评论可以和维特根斯坦关于心智错乱和外部世界怀疑论的看法相对照。

现在我们已经论证了前提（4）是真的，上述对 MFT 的论证也就是有效的。更广泛地，可以如下表述对 MFT 的辩护，其平行于王小塞对外部世界怀疑论的解决方案的表述：

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⑤在这里，自由意志怀疑论着可能会反对说安娜不可能选择其他选项（即安娜没有多重可能性）。一个回应是：我们可以区分向前看视角（forward-looking perspective）和向后看视角（backward-looking perspective）。只有在向后看视角下这样说才可能是合理的：安娜不可能选择其他选项，因为她的选择是被预先决定的。从向前看视角来看，在安娜做出最终决定之前，我们（和安娜自己）都不知道她将如何选择，因此她本有可能选择学校 A，B，或 C。

⑥ Jason Shepard 和 Shane Reuter（2012）使用实验论证了类似的论点。他们的实验结果表明“大众自由意志概念”（folk conception of free will）中的“选择”概念与“人们实际上别无选择”的反自由意志论证中的“选择”概念有着根本的不同。

（辩护） 任何对 MFT 的怀疑都可以被证明是错的，而任何看起来是对 MFT 的怀疑但无法被证明是错的怀疑，都是无意义的。

此外，由于对 MFT 的论证中使用的案例设定在一个普通的情境中，将这个论证一般化为对 NFT 的论证应该不难。

4.2 可能的反对意见

有人可能会提出反对意见：或许自由意志怀疑论者拥有足够充分的怀疑理由，因此他的言语并不会等同于无意义。如前所述，怀疑自由意志的主要动机是一般的决定论论题很可能是对的，以及（假定的）自由意志和决定论之间的不相容性。可以肯定的是，我们目前最先进的科学并没有决定性地支持因果决定论（见 Hoefer, 2023），但有可能某一天物理理论的发现表明，因果决定论确实是对的。在那种情况下，自由意志怀疑论者可能会说他的表达式，例如“安娜在选择学校时没有多重可能性”，在任何使用情境下都会有具体、实际的意义——其指向一种真正的或深刻的“多重可能性”。

我的回答是，我思虑、选择和行动的方式不会因为这个发现而改变。约翰 •费舍尔（John Fischer, 2007）表达了类似的观点，他说他可以想象在某个早晨醒来时看到报纸的标题 “因果决定论是对的！”但同时“这不会，也不应该改变我对自己和他人作为（有时）自由和强健的道德责任主体的看法。”在这个意义上，我对自由意志的论证与因果决定论或一般的决定论论题的对错无关。

第五章 结论

> 人类自由面临着真实的威胁，但它们不是形而上学的。有政治束缚、胁迫、由虚假信息的传播诱发的操控……这些对我们的自由的真实而多样的威胁的经验产生了焦虑，并提供了激发和（往往是隐蔽地）引导……[关于自由意志的]论证和分析的隐喻。（Dennette, 1984:169）

人们经常感到自己的意志行使受到了限制，人们有时惊讶地发现自己的行动为某些因素所决定，这引起了对于全局的缺乏自由意志的怀疑和恐惧。然而，本文最后部分的论证表明，对自由意志——决定我们行动路线的能力和发起行动的能力——的许多怀疑是错误的。对这种控制能力的否认，如果在某些情境下表达出来，将等同于无意义；其导致的不是对情况更清晰的判断，而是不负责任、漠不关心和退缩认命。

从安娜与简的案例中可以看出，我们确实有能力进行理性思虑、在多种可能性中进行选择，从而（在一定程度上）决定我们自己和我们的未来。当然，这只是一个案例，并不能覆盖自由意志的所有种类（如果存在不同种类的话）[⑦]，而且极小自由意志论题（MFT）也只是一个开始。然而，我相信，为 MFT 辩护时采用的反怀疑策略具有普遍的应用，其或许承诺了一种适当的正常自由意志论题（NFT）。NFT 将提供的自由意志可能无法满足最顽固的自由意志怀疑论者，但肯定是一个强大的自由意志。例如，它肯定提供了对抗胁迫、操控等等的能力，并且可以说是那种“值得欲求的[⑧]”自由意志。

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⑦ 然而，我同意凯恩的观点，他认为选择或者决定在自由意志的理论中有着核心地位，因为它们本质上“形成和创造了在现在或未来引领行动的意图和目标”（1998:24）。

⑧ 这是丹内特在《值得欲求的自由意志的不同种类》（Elbow room: the varieties of free will worth wanting）一书中使用的短语。

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A Semantic Response to Free Will Scepticism

Abstract

This essay discusses scepticism of free will, its similarity with scepticism of an external world, and a solution to scepticism of an external world that Moore and Wittgenstein worked towards. The essay presents a parallel semantic response to scepticism of free will and defends the minimal free will thesis (MFT), which holds that someone sometimes wills freely. It is argued that any doubt about MFT can be proved to be false, but whatever appears to be doubt about MFT that cannot be proved to be false is nonsense.

Keywords: free will, scepticism, nonsense, determinism

1 Introduction

Do we have free will? The debate over this gripping question is ancient but perennial. In particular, the development of science in recent decades has brought the issue to the centre again (see 韩 2019). Free will sceptics believe that free will does not exist, as free will is incompatible with determinism and determinism is very likely to be true. Yet most people feel that free will is so important for the conception of ourselves and others that it is nearly impossible to do without it.

Scepticism of an external world has similarities with scepticism of free will in both structures of arguments and the significance of problems. In this essay, the anti-sceptical strategy employed by Moore and Wittgenstein to address the former problem is applied to the latter. The minimal free will thesis (MFT) is defended, which holds that someone sometimes wills freely. It is further suggested that MFT and its generalization would provide the kind of free will worth wanting.

The essay is divided into three main sections. The first section considers two interpretations of the term “free will”, the challenge from determinism, and the significance of free will. The second section discusses Wittgensteinian nonsense and how it is applied in the solution to scepticism of an external world. The third section develops an argument for the minimal free will thesis (MFT), using a case of deliberation and the criticism of nonsense.

2 Free Will as a Problem

2.1 Interpretations of free will

Free will has traditionally been conceived of as a kind of power to control one’s choices and actions. How to pin down the exact nature or detailed content of free will, however, is difficult. Contemporary philosophers have developed two main kinds of interpretations of this term.

The first, "leeway theory", explains free will in terms of multiple possibilities facing the agent (see van Inwagen 1983). When an agent exercises free will over some choice or action, she has alternative possibilities with respect to that choice or action, that is, she can choose or act in one way and can do otherwise. This is a widely acknowledged feature of free will, which can be seen in historical literature. Aristotle says "when acting is up to us, so is not acting" (2009:1113b6), and Kant argues that for true freedom "the act as well as its opposite must be within the power of the subject at the moment of its taking place" (1960:45).

The second, "sourcehood theory", stresses that free choice or action "belongs to" the agent (see Kane 1998 and Pereboom 2014). Under this interpretation, an agent exercises free will over some choice or action if and only if she (rather than other people or factors beyond her control) is the source of that choice or action. This emphasis on source or origin can also be seen in historical literature: Aristotle characterizes involuntary action as "of which the moving principle is outside [the person who acts]", for example when a person is "carried somewhere by a wind" (2009:1110a2). Some philosophers think free will requires the agent's being the source of her choices and actions in an ultimate sense; Robert Kane, for instance, designates free will to mean "the power of agents to be the ultimate creators (or originators) and sustainers of their own ends or purposes"(1998:4).

There have been disputes over the relationship between these two interpretations. Specifically, Harry Frankfurt (1969) and Daniel Dennett (1984) have argued that the power to do otherwise is not required for free will. To use Dennett's case, when Luther said "Here I stand. I can do no other," on the occasion of his breaking with the church in Rome, the conscience of Luther made it impossible for him to do otherwise, yet Luther was not avoiding responsibility for his act but taking full responsibility for it. If we associate free will with moral responsibility, we cannot suppose that free will implies that the agent "could have done otherwise" (1984:133). By contrast, Kane argues to be the ultimate source or to take ultimate responsibility for one's actions requires at least some actions in one's life to have alternative possibilities (1984:72). Here I shall maintain that both interpretations intuitively capture certain attributes of the meaning of free will, and will not favour one theory over the other.

2.2 The challenge from determinism

The traditional notion of free will is challenged by determinism for the following two reasons.

First, there is a tension between whatever interpretation of free will and the general thesis of determinism. As an example, we shall consider the specific thesis of causal determinism: every event is necessitated by antecedent events and conditions together with the laws of nature. Consider the "leeway theory" of free will: if causal determinism is true, then at a time *t*, the way things go (including an agent's choice or action) is fixed, since both events before *t* and the laws of nature are fixed. It follows that when an agent chooses to act in one way, there is no real possibility that she could have chosen to act in another way; hence, she does not have free will. Consider the "sourcehood theory" of free will: if causal determinism is true, then an agent's choice and action are determined by past events and the laws of nature. It follows that genetics, past events together with physical and biological laws, rather than herself, are the real source of her choice;

hence, she does not have free will. It seems that under whatever interpretation, the existence of free will is not compatible with causal determinism.

Second, there are strong motivations behind the truth of the general thesis of determinism. In history, the motivation has been theological (e.g., Boethius discusses the problem of divine foreknowledge and human freedom) or metaphysical and has become increasingly scientific since the modern period. The success of Newtonian physics has contributed to a deterministic worldview in the modern period; some see the quantum revolution of the early twentieth century as challenging that deterministic worldview. However, there are currently competing deterministic and non-deterministic interpretations of quantum mechanics, and many thinkers hold doubt about the relevance of quantum mechanics to both consciousness and free will (see Hodgson 2011). For example, Dennett (1984:77) thinks that microscopic quantum effects in the world (and in our brains) would not involve macroscopic indeterminism of human action.

Advancements in neuroscience have also contributed to the belief of determinism, as neuroscientists continue to offer more and more accurate explanations and predictions of human behaviour by relating it with localized activity in the brain. Notably, neuroscientist Benjamin Libet (1985) conducted some experiments that seemed to reveal certain patterns of neural activity reliably precede people's conscious decisions to act, and Wegner (2002) argues on the basis of these findings that the experience of conscious willing is 'an illusion'.

2.3 The significance of free will

Although determinism poses a serious challenge to free will, the notion of free will has a fundamental importance in many aspects of human life that it would be nearly impossible to discard it. Without free will, the conception of ourselves as deliberative and rational agents would be significantly undermined, if not totally lost. This has at least two major consequences.

One is that there would be no room for moral responsibility. For an agent to be morally responsible, she needs to be choosing and acting voluntarily, i.e., out of her own free will. It seems unfair to blame an agent if her actions are purely determined by factors beyond her control, or if she does not have another choice. Therefore, it seems that if free will does not exist, we cannot take people to be morally responsible as we normally do. The result is far-reaching: from interpersonal relationships to judicial practice, and even to the fundamental notion of morality, all moral aspects of human life would be adversely affected.

Another is that the conception of self-determination and self-governance would be jeopardized. If the choices and actions of our lives do not (ultimately) originate from ourselves but from, for instance, our genetic make-ups and upbringings, it seems that we are not designers of our own lives but are (completely) subject to the manipulation of external factors. Closely related to this conception of self-determination is the conception of self-governance. For example, Kant associates freedom of the will with "autonomy" (or "self-legislation"), that is, being able to act in accordance with laws of one's own choosing rather than acting merely in accordance with nature's laws or rules imposed by other persons (1998:52). Without an underived origination by the will, Kant argues, the actions of free agents would be entirely subject to laws not of their own making.

The main concern of this essay is free will in connection with its significance of the second sort. This essay will not treat, at least not explicitly, the notion of moral responsibility, blameworthy and praiseworthy, etc.

3 An External World Anti-sceptic Strategy

3.1 Sceptical Arguments and Similarities

The problem of free will can be construed as a problem of scepticism -- at the heart of the problem is doubt about something (in this case, the existence of free will) which is valuable in human life and we normally take for granted. Indeed, the sceptical argument of free will shares similar structure and features with the sceptical argument of (knowledge of) an external world. Both arguments go from ordinary, local doubt to unusual, global doubt, employing one part of common sense to challenge other parts of common sense.

The sceptical argument in epistemology starts from the ordinary observation that we sometimes lack knowledge which we mistakenly took ourselves to have, such as in the case of optical illusion. The reasoning is then applied to unusual sceptical scenarios such as Descartes's evil demon: since we might be in this kind of scenario, we do not know what we ordinarily take ourselves to know about the external world.

Similarly, the sceptical argument of free will starts from the common-sense claim that sometimes we do not will freely, for instance when we are drugged. This local manipulation is then generalized to global manipulation: could all our choices or actions be controlled or determined by other forces -- be that genetics, natural laws, or fate? Could we lack free will in whatever circumstances?

The similarity in problems prompts us to investigate whether similar anti-sceptical strategies could work. Moore responds to external world scepticism in a series of papers, including “A Defence of Common Sense” and “Proof of an External World”. Wittgenstein also treats the topic of epistemology scepticism in *On Certainty*, which was stimulated by his reflections on Moore's two papers mentioned above. Interpretations of the two philosophers' anti-sceptical strategies vary. Most recently, Sebastian Sunday Grève (2022) noted that there is a “perfect alliance” between their strategies and suggested that Moore and Wittgenstein were working towards the same solution but left their work unfinished. This solution is logical or semantic in nature: “Any doubt about the existence of an external world can be proved to be false, but whatever appears to be doubt about the existence of an external world that cannot be proved to be false is nonsense, insofar as it must rely on the assertion of something that is logically impossible.”

3.2 Wittgensteinian Nonsense

This criticism of “nonsense” is deeply connected with Wittgenstein's view of meaning. Wittgenstein is sometimes understood as putting forward a “use-theory of meaning”, as exhibited in his claim in *Philosophical Investigations* §43: “For a *large* class of cases of the employment of the word ‘meaning’ -- though not for all -- this word can be explained in this way: the meaning of a word is its use in the language.” However, as James Conant (1998) remarks, this emphasis on usage should not be interpreted as merely supplementing our syntactic and semantic theory with a

third layer of the pragmatics of natural language. “The meaning of an expression” is not inherently possessed by the expression like “an atmosphere accompanying the word” and later imported into each occasion of use. Rather, it is only in its context of significant use, in the special circumstances in which the sentence is actually used that the sentence does make sense.

Under this interpretation, Wittgenstein's criticism of “nonsense” is not to mean that the employments of certain combinations of expressions in certain contexts are inherently nonsensical. His point of charging the sceptics with “nonsense” is that it is not clear what the context of use of the expression of doubt is supposed to be; it is this confusion of context of use that leads to their failure to mean something determinate -- a failure of making sense. Wittgenstein sometimes describes this situation of nonsensical utterance as “speaking outside language games” or “language goes on holiday”, that is, the words fail to be at work in the actual circumstances of use. We should really ask the sceptics: what are they doing with their words?

Conant answers that the sceptics are confused with their words: they want to mean more than one thing with their words. He summarizes that the sceptic is faced with a dilemma: either “he stays within our language-games and his words express a doubt but not the sort of super-doubt that he is after” (not the kind of doubt that will threaten the possibility of knowledge) or “he will be led to speak ‘outside language-games’, stripping his putative context of use of the concrete specificity”. Wittgenstein also refers to the latter situation as “the hallucination of meaning” -- mistakenly thinking that we know what our words mean while in fact not knowing what we mean by them.

3.3 A Solution to Scepticism

As an example, here we consider a sceptic who expresses his doubt about “here is a hand”. Now he might mean that it is possible that this is not a human hand but a prosthesis, or that this is not a real hand but an image produced by some projector. These are empirical propositions that can be proved to be false in normal circumstances. In response to this, the sceptic then adds the scepticism scenario to his doubt: “You may be dreaming! How can you know here is a hand?” Then we should ask why dreaming should damage our knowledge. The concept of dreaming we ordinarily use refers to a temporary experience in which our cognitive capacities and sensory experiences are compromised compared to those in our lucid states. It is in this kind of dream that we do not possess knowledge about an external world -- some objects that appeared in the dream may in fact be non-existent. However, it can be argued that the vivid sensory experiences and the memories (together with the coherent thinking process) we experience now do not resemble the dreams on which we normally employ the word “dream”. Therefore, the notion of dream the sceptic actually means in his new expression of doubt should be essentially different from our current notion of dream. This is the consideration Sunday Grève puts forward at the end of his paper, following Moore's question of “whether it is logically possible that I should *both* be having all the sensory experiences and the memories that I have and *yet* be dreaming” in “Certainty”.

Further, according to Wittgenstein, a series of false beliefs of the sort ‘I do not know that there is a hand (etc.)’ amounts not to a series of mistakes but to insanity. In *On Certainty* §67 and §71, Wittgenstein considers a case in which someone keeps on making mistakes where we normally do not, such as when “he says he lives in such and such a place, is so and so old, comes

from such and such a city, and he speaks with the same certainty (giving all the tokens of it) as I do, but he is wrong." He then reaches the conclusion that a one-time false belief like that might be called a mistake, but a regular series of a significant amount of these false beliefs is rather "a mental disturbance, perhaps a transient one". For this kind of mistake is impossible -- logically, because the propositions saying that here is a physical object (or that someone lives in such and such a place, is so and so old) possess a unique logical status. This impossibility is reiterated in the remarks:

> 155. In certain circumstances a man cannot make a *mistake.* ...
> 220. The reasonable man does not have certain doubts.

4 A Response to Free Will Scepticism

4.1 A Case of Choice

In this section, I present an argument to the conclusion that free will exists at least in a minimal sense. For the sake of argument, I will defend a minimal free will thesis (MFT) defined below. This is a weak thesis, and clearly a necessary condition for us to "have free will". It may or may not be a sufficient condition for free will, but I think a stronger thesis like NFT can be defended without much difficulty if the following defence of MFT succeeds.

(MFT) *Minimal Free Will Thesis*[1] Someone sometimes wills freely.

Specifically, this means at some time, someone has (leeway theory) alternative possibilities with regard to her choice or action, and (sourcehood theory) she is the source of that choice or action.

(NFT) *Normal Free Will Thesis* Normal people in normal circumstances will freely reasonably often.

My strategy is best illustrated through an example, which is set in an ordinary situation with nothing unusual.

(Anna vs. Jane) Both Anna and Jane have recently applied to grad schools; Anna has been offered admission to three schools, but Jane only got one offer. Anna has powerful motives for wanting to choose each of the options for different and incommensurable reasons[2]. After some time of deliberation, she finally clears the uncertainty and indecision and makes a choice. Jane is disappointed with the only option offered to her, but she accepts the offer involuntarily.

[1] This is an adaptation of the term used by van Inwagen (1983:91).
[2] The condition of "immensurable alternatives" is taken from Kane (1998:167). The overall design of this case is influenced by Kane's theory of "self-forming action".

The argument for MFT is then formulated as follows:

(1) If MFT is false, then both Anna and Jane do not will freely when they choose schools.

(2) If both Anna and Jane do not will freely when they choose schools, then both Anna and Jane do not have alternative possibilities when they choose schools.

(3) If MFT is false, then both Anna and Jane do not have alternative possibilities when they choose schools.

(4) It is not the case that both Anna and Jane do not have alternative possibilities when they choose schools.

(5) Therefore, MFT is true.

Premise (1) is the negation of MFT applied to the special case of Anna and Jane choosing schools. (2) follows from the "leeway theory" interpretation of free will. (3) follows from (1) and (2). (5) follows from (3) and (4) by *modus tollens.* This argument is valid in form and premises (1)(2)(3) are true. In order to establish the soundness of the argument, we only need to prove premise (4).

To see why (4) is true, consider the expression "both Anna and Jane do not have alternative possibilities when they choose schools" in the actual circumstance of Anna and Jane deciding which grad schools to go to. When Anna carefully weighs the pros and cons of each school, imagines what her future will be like if she chooses some option, and goes back and forth between several options, she is choosing among multiple possibilities. Even if Anna finally settles the uncertainty and chooses school A, she might well have chosen school B or C, given the equally powerful yet different motives she has for each option.[③] However, Jane does not need and, in fact, cannot choose among schools (assuming Jane really wants to go to grad school and does not consider other life possibilities at this time). We and Jane herself know that she is going to this particular school long before the final decision time. There are no alternative possibilities to her choice of school.

As in the case of external world scepticism, the philosophical criticism of "nonsense" can be applied here. It is not clear what the expression "both Anna and Jane do not have alternative possibilities when they choose schools" will do in this context of use. Does the employment of the expression make it unnecessary for Anna to deliberate? Surely it does not. The free will sceptic may want to target a kind of genuine or deep "alternative possibilities", but he confuses the context of use. This confusion results in the expression failing to be at work in any actual circumstance of use, hence stopping being meaningful. In a similar vein, the free will sceptic is faced with a dilemma: either his words express doubt about alternative possibilities but not the sort of alternative possibilities he is after when he doubts MFT, or his words fail to be at work and do not make sense. Therefore, either "both Anna and Jane do not have alternative possibilities when they

[③] Here a free will sceptic might object that Anna could not have chosen otherwise (have alternative possibilities). A reply is that we can distinguish between the forward-looking perspective and the backward-looking perspective. It is from the backward-looking perspective that it may be reasonable to say that Anna could not have chosen otherwise for her choice is pre-determined. From the forward-looking perspective, before Anna is to reach a final decision, we (and Anna herself) do not know what she will choose, hence she could choose school A, B, or C.

choose schools" is false (hence (4) is true), or the expression "both Anna and Jane do not have alternative possibilities when they choose schools" does not make sense[④].

To show the nonsense of the expression "both Anna and Jane do not have alternative possibilities when they choose schools" in a more intuitive way, consider this scenario. Somehow Anna believes she does not have alternative possibilities when choosing a school and there is no need to deliberate, just like Jane. Convinced of the needlessness of deliberation, she then decides to use dice-rolling to choose a school. If Anna were to roll a die to determine her choice of school (instead of gathering information and reasoning carefully), we should not say she lacks alternative possibilities or she does not will freely but she is apathetic and irresponsible for herself. Imagine Anna were to use this method to determine every big decision of her life, then we should say she abandons herself to despair. This is interesting when compared with Wittgenstein's remarks about mental disturbance and external world scepticism.

Now that premise (4) is shown to be true, the above argument for MFT is sound. More generally, a defence for MFT can be formulated like this, in parallel to Sunday Grève's formulation of his solution to external world scepticism:

(defence) Any doubt about MFT can be proved to be false, but whatever appears to be doubt about MFT that cannot be proved to be false is nonsense.

In addition, since the case used in the argument for MFT is set in an ordinary situation, a generalization to an argument for NFT should not be difficult.

4.2 A Possible Objection

It may be objected that the grounds for the free will sceptic's doubt are strong enough so that his words will not amount to nonsense. As discussed before, the main motivation behind doubt about free will is the probable truth of the general thesis of determinism and the presumed incompatibility between free will and determinism. To be sure, our current best science does not conclusively support determinism (see Hoefer 2023), but it is possible that someday a discovery in physical theory shows that causal determinism turns out to be true. In that situation, the free will sceptic might say his expression of, for instance, "Anna does not have alternative possibilities when choosing school" would have a concrete meaning in any circumstance of use, which points to a genuine or deep kind of "alternative possibilities".

My reply is that the way I deliberate, choose, and act will not change upon this discovery. John Fischer (2007) expresses similar sentiments, saying he could imagine waking up some morning to the newspaper headline "Causal Determinism Is True!" but "this would not, nor should it, change my view of myself and others as (sometimes) free and robustly morally responsible agents". In this sense, my argument for free will is agnostic about the truth of causal determinism or the general thesis of determinism.

④ Jason Shepard and Shane Reuter (2012) used experiments to argue a similar point. Their empirical findings show that the notion of choice in "folk conception of free will" is essentially different from the notion of choice in the "people do not really make choices" anti-free-will argumentation.

5 Conclusion

> There are real threats to human freedom, but they are not metaphysical. There is political bondage, coercion, the manipulation inducible by the dissemination of misinformation … Our experiences with these real and variable threats to our freedom generate the anxieties and provide the metaphors that motivate and (often covertly) guide the arguments and analyses … [about free will]. (Dennett 1984:169)

The constraints people often feel exerted on their wills, and the determinants people sometimes alarmingly detect on their actions, arouse doubt and fear of a global absence of free will. The argumentation in the last part of the essay shows, however, that much doubt about free will – the power to decide our courses of action and the power to initiate actions – is mistaken. The denial of this kind of power and control, expressed in certain circumstances, will amount to nonsense, which leads not to a clearer judgement about situations but to irresponsibility, apathy, and resignation.

As can be seen in the case of Anna vs. Jane, we do have the capacity to rationally deliberate, to choose among multiple possibilities, and thereby to determine (to an extent) ourselves and our futures. This is, of course, only one case which does not cover all varieties (if there are) of free will[⑤], and the minimal free will thesis (MFT) is just a start. I believe, however, the anti-sceptical strategy employed in defending MFT has general applications, which hold the promise of a suitable kind of normal free will thesis (NFT). The free will that NFT would provide may not satisfy the most stubborn free will sceptic, but is certainly a powerful one. It certainly, for instance, provides the capacity to fight against coercion, manipulation, etc., and is arguably the free will "worth wanting"[⑥].

[⑤] Nonetheless, I agree with Kane that choices or decisions play a pivotal role in accounts of free will, insofar as it essentially "form intentions and create purposes that guide actions, now or in the future" (1998:24).
[⑥] A phrase used by Daniel Dennett in his *Elbow room: the varieties of free will worth wanting.*

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